BADAMI ROCK-CUT CAVE TEMPLES (??????)

HISTORICAL CAPITAL OF THE CHALUKYAS

Badami, originally known as Vatapi, was the regal capital of the Early Chalukya dynasty from 540 to 757 CE, established by King Pulakeshin I. Nestled in a rugged sandstone ravine in Bagalkot district, the settlement developed around the artificial Agastya Tirtha water reservoir, flanked by towering red sandstone cliffs.

THE FOUR MONUMENTAL ROCK-CUT CAVES

The rock-cut temples are carved horizontally into the steep cliff face, arranged chronologically from Cave 1 at the lowest level to Cave 4 at the highest elevation. Each cave comprises an entrance verandah (mukhamandapa), a columned main hall (mahamandapa), and a small square sanctum (garbhagriha) hollowed deep into the living rock.

DETAILED DESCRIPTIONS OF BADAMI CAVES

Cave 1 (Shaivism):
Dedicated to Lord Shiva, carved around 550 CE. Features the iconic 18-armed dancing Nataraja relief portraying 81 distinct mudras and postures of classical dance. Also contains monumental reliefs of Harihara (half Shiva, half Vishnu) and Ardhanarishvara (half Shiva, half Parvati).

Cave 2 (Vaishnavism):
Dedicated to Lord Vishnu, reached by a flight of 64 steps from Cave 1. Noted for colossal ceiling carvings and relief panels of Vishnu in his cosmic avatar Trivikrama (Vamana) with one foot planted on Earth and another raised to the heavens, as well as the boar avatar Varaha rescuing Bhudevi.

Cave 3 (Maha-Vishnu):
The largest and most elaborately carved cave, bearing a crucial Sanskrit foundation inscription dated to Saka 500 (578 CE) during the reign of King Kirtivarman I by his brother King Mangalesha. Famous for the magnificent 8-armed seated Vishnu on the coiled serpent Shesha (Anantasayana) and the fearsome seated Narasimha.

JAIN CAVE AND LAKESIDE MONUMENTS

Cave 4 (Jainism):
Carved in the late 6th to early 7th century CE, dedicated to Jain Tirthankaras. The sanctum holds a serene sculpture of Lord Mahavira seated on a lion throne (Simhasana). The verandah walls feature Parshvanatha sheltered by a multi-hooded cobra and Bahubali (Gommata) standing in deep kayotsarga meditation with creepers climbing his legs.

BHUTANATHA TEMPLE COMPLEX
Located on the eastern edge of Agastya Lake, the Bhutanatha group of sandstone temples dates from the 7th to 11th centuries. Built in early Dravida style, its open mandapa extends directly into the tranquil lake waters, creating one of Karnataka's most famous heritage vistas.